founder Keshav Baliram Hedgewar as the central organism at the heart of the Sangh when he founded it on Vijayadashami (Dussehra), 27 September 1925.[19] Hedgewar envisaged a strong network of shakhas where 'Hindus would gather and refurbish the values of life'. According to K.S. Sudarshan, who headed the RSS between 2000 and 2009, Hedgewar forged the 'shakha with its auto-financing system and deep-rooted traditions as moorings to mould the Hindus so that we can stand before the world as a mighty confident nation'.[20]

Daily shakhas are thus the fundamental building blocks of the Sangh. They consist, according to one description, of physical warm-up and jogging (five minutes), yoga and surya namaskar (forty minutes), Sanskrit shlokas called Subhashit or Amrit Vachan or patriotic songs (ten minutes) followed by prayers for five minutes.[21] Hedgewar saw the shakhas as 'incubators for vyakti-nirman [personality development]'. As senior Sangh leader Sunil Ambekar puts it, for Hedgewar, 'Sangh means Shakha and Shakha means programmes for personality development'.[22]

The expansion of shakhas was accompanied by a major increase in RSS training camps for existing members between 2014 and 2019 (see Figure 12.3). Annual RSS Officer Training Camps (Level 1) increased by 49.8 per cent in this period (from 10,435 to 15,639), Level 2 Training Camps by 49.4 per cent (from 2,231 to 3,335) and Level 3 Training Camps by 15.8 per cent (from 607 to 703).

Figure 12.3: Annual Growth of RSS Officer Training Camps—Levels 1, 2 and 3 (1994–2019)